POU11011: Introduction to Political Science A

Module outline — Michaelmas Term 2026

15 October 2026

Term	Michaelmas Term 2026
Credits	5 ECTS
Lecturer	Dr Noah Buckley — noah.buckley@tcd.ie
Office hours	By appointment
Lectures	Tues 11am B101, Fri 1pm Goldsmith
Tutorials	Four across the term
Assessment	Discussion points 10% · blog post 30% · final essay 60%
Teaching assistants	Jennifer Moynihan (Head TA), Charlotte Bassewitz, Sara-Meryem Efe, Nalia Feree, Ali Ghareh Daghi, Swan Jehan, Jomilin John, Francesca Keogh · contact details for your own TA are on Blackboard
Course website	noahbuckley.me/teaching/pou11011-mt2026

Module description

This module introduces you to the big questions in politics and to the conceptual, theoretical, and analytical tools that political scientists use to answer them. It is designed both for students who intend to study politics for the rest of their degree and for those taking a single, standalone introduction to the discipline.

We start from the basics — what politics *is*, what power is, why states exist and why some of them work and others don't. From there we take on ideologies and political identity, democracy and dictatorship and the grey zone in between, corruption and state capture, political institutions, and the question of who gets what in the economy. We close on the two things that make political science a *science*: collective action problems, and how you would ever know whether a claim about politics is true.

The goal is not to memorise facts. It is to learn to think like a political scientist: to ask sharper questions, compare across cases, and carry a small toolkit of portable concepts into political situations you have never seen before.

Aims

The module has two aims: (1) to give you a basic knowledge of the key problems and questions around which politics revolves; and (2) to equip you with the fundamental conceptual, theoretical, and analytical tools used in the consideration of political questions.

Learning outcomes

On successful completion of this module, you should be able to:

- Identify and understand the key problems and questions around which politics revolves.
- Employ the fundamental conceptual, theoretical, and analytical tools used in the consideration of political questions.
- Critically engage with and analyse contemporary national and global political events and issues using the tools and frameworks of political science.

How the module works

Lectures

There are two lectures per week, Tuesdays at 11am and Fridays at 1pm. Attendance is not taken and there is no penalty for missing a lecture, but the lectures are where the module actually happens. Material will be covered in lecture that is not in the readings, and the slides are a prompt for what I say, not a transcript of it. You will not be able to reconstruct a lecture from the slides, and tutorials are not a place to catch up on lectures you missed. To do well here you need to do the readings, come to the lectures, *and* take part in tutorial discussion.

Slides will be posted on the course website.

Tutorials

There are **four fortnightly tutorial sessions** across the term, run in small groups by our teaching assistants. Tutorials are not repeat lectures: they are where you ask questions, argue with the readings, give your views or thoughts to the room, and hear what your classmates make of them.

Attendance at tutorials is compulsory and is linked to assessment (see below).

You will be allocated a tutorial group, the timetable for which will appear in your my.tcd.ie timetable.

Tutorials are a place for open, warm, and sometimes contentious discussion. People in the room have different backgrounds, experiences, and personal stakes in these questions. Everyone is expected to engage seriously with the arguments and generously with the people making them.

Readings and the textbook

The core text for this module is:

> **Andrew Heywood & Matthew Laing, *Politics*, 6th edition (Bloomsbury, 2025).**

Chapter numbering is unchanged from the 2019 5th edition. A PDF copy is provided in the **Textbook** item on Blackboard.

Each week has a small number of **required readings**, generally from this textbook, which you should complete *before* the relevant lecture, plus **recommended readings** for going deeper, for the assignments, and for your own interest. Journal articles beyond the textbook you find yourself, through the Library or Google Scholar; book chapters and anything else hard to find are provided via Blackboard, and links will be available on the course webpage. Some weeks also carry a short **Bonus** list — blog posts, essays, podcasts. These are not required, not examinable, and not substitutes for the other, more academic reading.

The reading list in the schedule below is indicative and may be adjusted during term; Blackboard and the course website carry the current version.

Assessment

Component	Weight
Discussion-point submissions + tutorial attendance	10%
Short written assignment (blog post)	30%
End-of-term final essay	60%

Full assignment instructions, prompts, and essay questions will be released in lecture and on Blackboard.

Discussion points and tutorial attendance (10%)

All four of this term's tutorials are required.

For each of the term's tutorials you must submit **a set of discussion points** — two or three numbered points, 200–400 words total, before the tutorial — and attend the tutorial in question. Both halves are required: points without attendance, or attendance without points, earn no credit for that tutorial.

You are not being asked for polished analysis. You are being asked to raise something worth group discussion. You can mention things you didn't understand in the readings, object to a point that has been made, add something to the content, or many other things.

Submissions are **pass/fail**: two points for each tutorial attended with an accepted submission, to a maximum of eight. Your TA can reject a submission that is too short or makes no genuine attempt at the reading. Deadline is **5pm the evening before** your tutorial meets, via Blackboard; nothing is accepted after the tutorial has met.

Department policy: this component is capped at 80. Perfect attendance and participation earns a mark of 80 for this component, with reductions proportional to that. This reflects the realities of the Trinity marking scale.

Full mechanics — what to write, what does not count, excused absence, the GenAI line — come in lecture and on Blackboard in due course.

Short assignment — blog post (30%)

An **800-word blog post** taking one concept from the module and using it to make sense of one real political situation.

- **Length:** 800 words.
- **Style:** rigorous but less formal than an academic essay. Headings, short paragraphs, bold text, links and images are all welcome; a real argument is required. It is not an opinion piece with citations bolted on, and it is not an essay with subheadings.
- **Sources:** cite **at least two** academic readings or materials from the module.
- **Prompts and details will be provided** at least three weeks before the due date, in lecture and on Blackboard.
- **Due:** Friday 23 October 2026, 23:59.

Final essay (60%)

A **1,500-word essay** answering one of several set questions, drawing on the concepts, tools, and cases from across the module. I am looking for more than just rote repetition: take a position, compare across cases, and reason with the module's materials.

- **Length:** 1,500 words.
- **Prompts and details will be provided** at least three weeks before the due date, in lecture and on Blackboard.
- **Due:** Tuesday 15 December 2026, 23:59.

There is no exam. Questions, how to structure an argumentative essay at this level, citation expectations and the GenAI permissions come with the essay sheet.

Written work: format requirements

In line with department guidelines, written work for this module must:

- state the final word count, and observe the word limit — **limits carry a 10% tolerance either way, and going outside that range costs up to 5 marks**;
- be submitted to Blackboard in Word or PDF, with the Assignment Submission Form as page 1;
- use consistent citation and referencing (the TCD Library style guide will help);
- include an alphabetised bibliography;
- be spellchecked.

Back your work up, and submit early enough to survive a technical problem. Keep your submission receipt. Computer crashes, corrupted files, and internet problems are not grounds for late submission.

Policies

Tutorial attendance and absences

You may only attend the tutorial on your timetable.

If you must miss a tutorial for a valid reason (medical, for example), email your TA at least 24 hours before the tutorial. If you want module credit for that tutorial, the discussion points must still be submitted — at or before the next tutorial, or within one week of the end of term if it relates to the last tutorial.

Late work

All late work, unless excused in advance by me, is penalised at **5 marks per day or part thereof, up to a maximum of 20 marks**. There are many good reasons a student cannot submit on time and I am happy to make reasonable accommodations. What is not reasonable is getting in touch after the deadline, or a few hours before it. Do not leave requests until the last minute. Department policy does not allow extensions to be granted retrospectively except in exceptional medical circumstances. Requests for extensions go through your College Tutor; late submission on medical grounds requires a medical certificate. Under no circumstances will work be accepted after it has been marked and returned to other students.

Contacting us

Contact your TA for: anything about module content, readings, tutorials, your discussion points, or how an assignment works goes to the teaching assistant who runs your tutorial group. They are closest to your work and they are happy to meet on request.

Come to me for: extensions, serious personal difficulty, a mark you believe is wrong after you have already discussed it with your TA, or a question about the module or its content as a whole. When you do, **copy your TA** so we are not answering you separately.

The TAs and I will do our best to reply within **two business days**. Emails sent at 10pm before a deadline will likely not be answered before it.

For substantive questions about the material, come to office hours (by appointment — email to arrange). I will not be able to fill you in on a lecture you missed, but I am happy to talk through anything you are uncertain about.

Disability

Students with a disability liable to affect their ability to participate fully in this — or any — module are encouraged to register with the University's Disability Service, which exists to make sure appropriate accommodations are in place.

Keeping up with current events

Read the news! Any serious source you like, national or international. Half the value of this module is having something concrete in your head when a concept turns up, and the other half is noticing that a concept explains something you read last week.

Academic integrity

Do not plagiarise. Academic dishonesty is a serious matter with serious consequences, up to and including no credit for the assignment, failure of the module, and expulsion. It is never permissible to submit work containing other people's ideas without acknowledgment, and careless note-taking is not an excuse: put direct quotations in quotation marks, and reference paraphrases too. Trinity's guidance is at libguides.tcd.ie/plagiarism, and if you have not already completed the Library's Ready, Steady, Write tutorial, do that before your first submission. You must also submit only *new* work — not work submitted previously for another module.

Generative AI

These tools exist, you likely use them, and you will likely use them in whatever you do after you get your degree. But this module is not assessing whether you can obtain a competent paragraph about political science from an LLM. It is assessing whether *you* can read an argument, understand it, find its weak and strong points, and put your own case in your own words. That capacity is built by doing the work, and it does not survive being outsourced. So the line I draw is this: **if you want to use GenAI (LLMs), use it to help you and to help you improve your prose; do not use it to do the thinking or produce the prose.**

What is permitted for each assessment is in that assessment's sheet, in the vocabulary of the School of Social Sciences and Philosophy Assignment Submission Form — the same words you tick on the form. "Permitted" means you may do it and must tick the corresponding box. "Not permitted" means doing it is an academic integrity matter, whether or not you disclose it.

Familiarise yourself with Trinity's Statement on Generative AI, the Library's GenAI guide, and the College GenAI hub.

The Assignment Submission Form

Every piece of written work submitted for this module must have the School of Social Sciences and Philosophy Assignment Submission Form attached as its first page. The form is on Blackboard in both Word and PDF. Complete it in full, including the plagiarism declaration and the GenAI disclosure — tick every category that applies to what you actually did, and use the *Other use* box if none of them fits.

A written submission received without a completed form will not be accepted. It will be returned to you unmarked, and the work will be treated as not submitted until you resubmit it with a completed form attached — accruing the late penalties set out under **Late work** above for every day in between. This is a departmental requirement and applies across the module.

The form does not count toward your word limit. Ticking a box that the policy above permits carries no penalty of any kind.

I reserve the right to modify this outline as necessary during term. The current version is always the one on the course website and Blackboard.

Schedule

Week numbers follow Trinity's teaching-week calendar (teaching week 1 begins 14 September); as a first-year module, this one starts lectures in teaching week 2.

Part I — Foundations

Teaching week 2 · Tue 22 & Fri 25 September

> **Big question: what is politics, and who actually decides?**

- **Lecture 1 — Introduction and "Is this politics?"** Politics as collective choice under conflict.
- **Lecture 2 — Power: who actually decides?** The three faces of power, and how you would ever observe the invisible ones.

Required:

- Andrew Heywood and Matthew Laing. 2025. *Politics*. 6th ed. Bloomsbury. Ch. 1.
- Andrew Heywood and Matthew Laing. 2025. *Politics*. 6th ed. Bloomsbury. Ch. 4, "Legitimacy and political stability" — Weber's three types of authority.

Recommended:

- Peter Bachrach and Morton S. Baratz. 1962. "Two Faces of Power." *American Political Science Review* 56(4): 947–952.
- Steven Lukes. 2005. *Power: A Radical View*. 2nd ed. Palgrave Macmillan.
- Bernard Crick. 1962. *In Defence of Politics*. Weidenfeld and Nicolson. Selected pages.
- Robert A. Dahl. 1957. "The Concept of Power." *Behavioral Science* 2(3): 201–215.

Teaching week 3 · Tue 29 September & Fri 2 October

> **Big question: where do states come from, and why can some of them actually do things?**

- **Lecture 3 — The state I: where do states come from?** Weber's monopoly of legitimate violence; war, taxes and bureaucracy.
- **Lecture 4 — The state II: why can some states actually do things?** State capacity, and why it is not one number.

Required:

- Andrew Heywood and Matthew Laing. 2025. *Politics*. 6th ed. Bloomsbury. Ch. 3, including the "Failed states" section.

Recommended:

- Max Weber. 1946. "Politics as a Vocation." In *From Max Weber: Essays in Sociology*, edited by H. H. Gerth and C. Wright Mills. Oxford University Press.
- Charles Tilly. 1985. "War Making and State Making as Organized Crime." In *Bringing the State Back In*, edited by Peter B. Evans, Dietrich Rueschemeyer and Theda Skocpol. Cambridge University Press. Pp. 169–191.
- Francis Fukuyama. 2013. "What Is Governance?" *Governance* 26(3): 347–368.

Part II — Ideas and identities

Teaching week 4 · Tue 6 & Fri 9 October

> **Big question: what are the big answers to who gets what, and who decides?**

- **Lecture 5 — Ideologies I: liberalism, conservatism, socialism.** Three serious answers to the distribution question.
- **Lecture 6 — Ideologies II: nationalism, fascism, feminism, green — and populism** as a thin ideology that attaches to any of them.

Required:

- Andrew Heywood and Matthew Laing. 2025. *Politics*. 6th ed. Bloomsbury. Ch. 2, including the "Anarchism" section.
- Andrew Heywood and Matthew Laing. 2025. *Politics*. 6th ed. Bloomsbury. Ch. 6, nations, types of nationalism, and "Nationalist politics".

Recommended:

- Jan-Werner Müller. 2016. *What Is Populism?* University of Pennsylvania Press. Ch. 1, "What Populists Say".
- Michael Freeden. 2003. *Ideology: A Very Short Introduction*. Oxford University Press. Ch. 1.

Teaching week 5 · Tue 13 & Fri 16 October

> **Big question: where do political identities come from, and when does difference become conflict?**

- **Lecture 7 — Where do political identities come from?** Why some identities become political and most never do.
- **Lecture 8 — When does difference become conflict?** Most diverse societies, most of the time, have no ethnic violence.

Required:

- Andrew Heywood and Matthew Laing. 2025. *Politics*. 6th ed. Bloomsbury. Ch. 6.
- Andrew Heywood and Matthew Laing. 2025. *Politics*. 6th ed. Bloomsbury. Ch. 8, "Race and ethnicity" and "Gender and identity" (in Identity politics).
- James D. Fearon. 1999. "What Is Identity (As We Now Use the Word)?" Unpublished manuscript, Department of Political Science, Stanford University.

Recommended:

- Benedict Anderson. 1991. *Imagined Communities: Reflections on the Origin and Spread of Nationalism*. Revised ed. Verso. Selected pages.
- David Yanagizawa-Drott. 2014. "Propaganda and Conflict: Evidence from the Rwandan Genocide." *Quarterly Journal of Economics* 129(4): 1947–1994. Introduction only, pp. 1947–1955.

Part III — Regimes

Teaching week 6 · Tue 20 & Fri 23 October

> **Big question: what is democracy, how would you measure it, and why does it survive?**

- **Lecture 9 — Democracy: what it is, and how you'd measure it.** Minimal against substantive definitions; three indices that disagree.
- **Lecture 10 — Democracy: why it emerges, why it survives.**

Required:

- Andrew Heywood and Matthew Laing. 2025. *Politics*. 6th ed. Bloomsbury. Ch. 4, except the "Models of democracy" section (that comes in week 8). This includes "Legitimacy and political stability".
- Andrew Heywood and Matthew Laing. 2025. *Politics*. 6th ed. Bloomsbury. Ch. 5, "Classifying political systems" and the regime-types sections.
- Philippe C. Schmitter and Terry Lynn Karl. 1991. "What Democracy Is… and Is Not." *Journal of Democracy* 2(3): 75–88.

Recommended:

- V-Dem Institute. *Democracy Report* (latest edition) — overview and key figures.
- Seymour Martin Lipset. 1959. "Some Social Requisites of Democracy: Economic Development and Political Legitimacy." *American Political Science Review* 53(1): 69–105. Selected pages.

Short assignment due Friday 23 October, 23:59.

Teaching week 7 — reading/review week, w/c Monday 26 October. No lectures, no tutorials. (Monday 26 October is a public holiday.) Teaching resumes with **teaching week 8 on Tuesday 3 November**.

Teaching week 8 · Tue 3 & Fri 6 November

> **Big question: what kind of democracy do we want — and what happens where there isn't one?**

- **Lecture 11 — What kind of democracy do we want?** Direct, representative, deliberative; Ireland's Citizens' Assembly.
- **Lecture 12 — Dictatorships: how autocracies work.** Repression, co-optation, and why hold an election you could cancel.

Required:

- Andrew Heywood and Matthew Laing. 2025. *Politics*. 6th ed. Bloomsbury. Ch. 4, "Models of democracy" section.
- Andrew Heywood and Matthew Laing. 2025. *Politics*. 6th ed. Bloomsbury. Ch. 5, "Authoritarian regimes" and "Hybrid regimes" sections.
- Sergei Guriev and Daniel Treisman. 2019. "Informational Autocrats." *Journal of Economic Perspectives* 33(4): 100–127.

Recommended:

- David M. Farrell and Jane Suiter. 2019. *Reimagining Democracy: Lessons in Deliberative*

Democracy from the Irish Front Line. Cornell University Press.
- Erica Frantz. 2018. *Authoritarianism: What Everyone Needs to Know*. Oxford University Press. Pp. 1–13.
- Michael L. Ross. 2001. "Does Oil Hinder Democracy?" *World Politics* 53(3): 325–361.

Teaching week 9 · Tue 10 & Fri 13 November

> **Big question: how do democracies rot — and how do you count something everybody hides?**

- **Lecture 13 — Democratic backsliding.** Not a coup: a slow, legal-looking hollowing-out.
- **Lecture 14 — Corruption and state capture.** How you measure a thing people lie about.

Required:

- Andrew Heywood and Matthew Laing. 2025. *Politics*. 6th ed. Bloomsbury. Ch. 5, "Democratic backsliding" and the Hungary case study, pp. 131-134.
- Nancy Bermeo. 2016. "On Democratic Backsliding." *Journal of Democracy* 27(1): 5–19.
- Daniel Treisman. 2010. " 'Loans for Shares' Revisited." NBER Working Paper 15819. Read for the argument; skip the regression tables.

Recommended:

- Kim Lane Scheppele. 2018. "Autocratic Legalism." *University of Chicago Law Review* 85(2): 545–583.
- Anna Lührmann and Staffan I. Lindberg. 2019. "A Third Wave of Autocratization Is Here: What Is New About It?" *Democratization* 26(7): 1095–1113.
- Anna Persson, Bo Rothstein and Jan Teorell. 2013. "Why Anticorruption Reforms Fail—Systemic Corruption as a Collective Action Problem." *Governance* 26(3): 449–471.

Part IV — Institutions and political economy

Teaching week 10 · Tue 17 & Fri 20 November

> **Big question: who can stop whom — and when do rules on paper actually bind rulers?**

- **Lecture 15 — What is a parliament actually for?** Representation, legislation, oversight — and why the Dáil does less of the second than you would think.
- **Lecture 16 — Rules and referees.** Constitutions, courts and veto players, and when paper constraints hold.

Required:

- Andrew Heywood and Matthew Laing. 2025. *Politics*. 6th ed. Bloomsbury. Ch. 15, and ch. 14 on executive–legislative relations.
- Andrew Heywood and Matthew Laing. 2025. *Politics*. 6th ed. Bloomsbury. Ch. 13.
- Andrew Heywood and Matthew Laing. 2025. *Politics*. 6th ed. Bloomsbury. Ch. 5, the "Veto player" concept box (Tsebelis), p. 129.

Recommended:

- Juan J. Linz. 1990. "The Perils of Presidentialism." *Journal of Democracy* 1(1): 51–69.
- Tom Ginsburg and Aziz Z. Huq. 2018. *How to Save a Constitutional Democracy*. University of Chicago Press. Chs. 3–4.

Teaching week 11 · Tue 24 & Fri 27 November

> **Big question: who gets what in the economy — and why doesn't more inequality produce more redistribution?**

- **Lecture 17 — Political economy I: states, markets, globalisation.**
- **Lecture 18 — Political economy II: inequality, redistribution, housing.** Irish housing as a political-economy problem.

Required:

- Andrew Heywood and Matthew Laing. 2025. *Politics*. 6th ed. Bloomsbury. Ch. 7.
- Larry M. Bartels. 2016. *Unequal Democracy: The Political Economy of the New Gilded Age*. 2nd ed. Princeton University Press. Ch. 1, pp. 1–32.

Recommended:

- Dani Rodrik. 1997. *Has Globalization Gone Too Far?* Institute for International Economics. Ch. 1, pp. 1–10.
- Michelle Norris and Michael Byrne. 2021. "The Political Economy of Housing in Ireland." In *The Oxford Handbook of Irish Politics*, edited by David M. Farrell and Niamh Hardiman. Oxford University Press. Pp. 499–518.
- Ben W. Ansell. 2014. "The Political Economy of Ownership: Housing Markets and the Welfare State." *American Political Science Review* 108(2): 383–402.

Part V — Closing

Teaching week 12 · Tue 1 & Fri 4 December

> **Big question: why do we fail at long-horizon problems — and how would we ever know we were right?**

- **Lecture 19 — Climate as a collective action problem.** Why democracies under-supply long-horizon goods.
- **Lecture 20 — How do we know?** How political scientists get fooled, and how they try not to be.

Required:

- TBA

Semester 1 teaching ends **Friday 4 December 2026**. The College assessment session runs **11–22 December 2026**. The final essay is due **Tuesday 15 December 2026, 23:59**.